

TOUGH CALL
ITBP personnel carry bodies of climbers to a chopper at a makeshift helipad

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was perfectly fine when they all started at 3:15 am to climb the peak. As he was not feeling comfortable on the long sling, he decided to self-anchor with a small rope. The decision probably saved his life. He had been in the 18th position on the long rope.

"There was no sound from the avalanche. It gave no warning, but pushed most of us into a 70-ft-deep crevasse. Along with five other instructors, who were somehow saved, I did my best to save our colleagues. But sadly, I could only save four and recovered four bodies," says Bhatt. The others were trapped inside the crevasse where they perished under the snow. According to mountaineers, it is a general rule of thumb that anyone stuck in a crevasse cannot survive beyond two hours.

News of the calamity was sent to the base camp by satellite phone and the first members of a rescue temam reached the spot within a couple of hours. As the NIM comes under the Union ministry of defence, Uttarakhand chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhami immediately dialled defence minister Rajnath Singh for urgent intervention, following which the Indian Air Force joined the rescue operation. With the weather on the mountain deteriorating, eight mountaineers, including Bhatt, came down to the base camp. Six others spent the night on the mountain with rescuers from the Indo Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) and were airlifted by IAF choppers the next day.

The ITBP's XII Battalion, based in Matli, had come as the first responder soon after receiving information from the district administration. A team of 12 mountaineers was air-dropped on the peak in the rescue mission. By then, however, it was clear that there were very few survivors, so their main task was to recover the bodies. The ITBP team camped there for the next five days, with the temperature dipping to -10°C at night. A makeshift helipad was set up at an altitude of 16,000 ft. "We had the toughest time handling the emotions of family members of the trapped mountaineers," says an official involved in the rescue operation. "For the first two days, they were still hoping for their kin's survival. They were not ready to accept the worst until they actually saw the bodies."

Kanchan Bisht, another survivor, says she just cannot get herself to recount the incident. "I am traumatised because I saw many of my friends dying in front of my eyes. I couldn't save them despite my best efforts. I did what I could to dig out their bodies." Kanchan was the first one on the long rope. "The moment I realised something was wrong, I detached myself from the rope. I managed to survive because I got stuck five metres away from the crevasse," she says.

The 41 mountaineers who attempted the climb to the summit were among a total of 150 who were at the Dokrani base camp set up at 12,600 ft. These mountaineers had been shortlisted for the advanced mountaineering course and had to trek four hours from the base camp